Client Onboarding Process Optimization Guide

CEPHO/The Brain Standard Operating Procedure

Version: 1.0 **Date:** January 15, 2026 **Status:** Active

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This guide provides the optimized process for onboarding new clients and opportunities into the CEPHO/The Brain system. It covers the complete journey from initial contact through to active engagement, ensuring consistent quality and maximum efficiency.

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1. ONBOARDING OVERVIEW

1.1 Objectives

The onboarding process aims to:

1. Capture all relevant information efficiently
2. Set clear expectations with clients
3. Establish proper tracking and documentation
4. Enable rapid deep dive analysis
5. Build strong client relationships from day one

1.2 Process Timeline

Phase	Duration	Key Activities
Initial Contact	Day 1	Capture, qualify, respond
Discovery	Days 2-3	Deep intake, document collection
Setup	Days 4-5	System configuration, team briefing
Kickoff	Day 6-7	Formal kickoff, expectations alignment
Active Engagement	Day 8+	Deep dive, analysis, delivery

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2. PHASE 1: INITIAL CONTACT

2.1 Lead Capture

Sources:

- Direct referral
- Website inquiry
- Outbound outreach
- Network introduction

Required Information:

Field	Required	Notes
Contact Name	Yes	Full name
Company/Project	Yes	Entity name
Email	Yes	Primary contact
Phone	Preferred	For urgent matters
Source	Yes	How they found us
Initial Interest	Yes	What they're looking for

2.2 Initial Response (Within 4 Hours)

Response Template:

```
Subject: Re: [Inquiry Topic] - CEPHO Response

Dear [Name],

Thank you for reaching out to CEPHO. We're excited to learn more about
[Company/Project] and how we might support your objectives.

To ensure we can provide the most relevant insights, I'd like to schedule
a brief 30-minute discovery call at your earliest convenience.

Please let me know your availability over the next few days, or feel free
to book directly: [Scheduling Link]

In the meantime, if you have any initial documents or materials you'd like
us to review, please feel free to share them.

Best regards,
[Name]
CEPHO Team
```

2.3 Qualification Criteria

Scoring Matrix:

Criterion	Weight	Score (1-5)
Strategic Fit	25%	Does this align with CEPHO focus areas?
Opportunity Size	20%	Potential value of engagement
Timeline	15%	Urgency and decision timeline
Budget Indication	15%	Ability to invest
Decision Authority	15%	Access to decision makers
Information Quality	10%	Quality of initial materials

Qualification Threshold: Score $\geq$ 3.5 = Proceed to Discovery

3. PHASE 2: DISCOVERY

3.1 Discovery Call Agenda (30-45 minutes)

Time	Topic	Purpose
0-5 min	Introduction	Build rapport, set agenda
5-15 min	Their Story	Understand background, context
15-25 min	Objectives	What success looks like
25-35 min	Challenges	Current obstacles, concerns
35-40 min	Our Approach	How CEPHO can help
40-45 min	Next Steps	Document requests, timeline

3.2 Discovery Questions

Business Understanding:

1. What is the core business/opportunity?
2. What stage are you at currently?
3. What's your timeline for key decisions?
4. Who are the key stakeholders?

Objectives:

1. What does success look like in 12 months?
2. What would make this engagement valuable?
3. What decisions are you trying to make?

Challenges:

1. What's your biggest uncertainty right now?
2. What have you tried before?

3. What's holding you back?

Resources:

1. What documents/data do you have available?
2. Who else should we speak with?
3. What's your budget/investment capacity?

3.3 Document Collection Checklist

Document Type	Priority	Purpose
Business Plan/Pitch Deck	Critical	Core understanding
Financial Projections	Critical	Viability assessment
Market Research	High	Market validation
Competitive Analysis	High	Positioning
Team Bios	Medium	Capability assessment
Legal Documents	Medium	Structure, IP
Customer Data	Medium	Traction evidence
Technical Documentation	Low	Product understanding

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4. PHASE 3: SYSTEM SETUP

4.1 CRM Configuration (Lightfield)

Create Contact Record:

- Full contact details
- Company information
- Source and referral tracking
- Initial qualification score

Create Opportunity:

- Opportunity name: [Company] - [Project Type]
- Stage: Discovery
- Expected value
- Expected close date
- Assigned team member

Set Up Automation:

- Welcome email sequence
- Document request reminders
- Follow-up scheduling
- Status update notifications

4.2 Project Folder Setup

Folder Structure:

```
/projects/[client-name]/
├── 01-intake/
│   ├── discovery-notes.md
│   ├── qualification-scorecard.md
│   └── received-documents/
├── 02-research/
│   ├── market-analysis/
│   ├── competitive-analysis/
│   └── financial-analysis/
├── 03-analysis/
│   ├── sme-expert-reviews/
│   ├── gap-analysis/
│   └── recommendations/
├── 04-deliverables/
│   ├── reports/
│   ├── presentations/
│   └── business-plans/
└── 05-communications/
    ├── meeting-notes/
    └── correspondence/
```

4.3 Team Briefing

Briefing Document:

Section	Content
Client Overview	Who they are, what they do
Opportunity	What we're helping with
Key Stakeholders	Who we're working with
Timeline	Key dates and milestones
Success Criteria	How we measure success
Risks/Concerns	What to watch out for
Resources	Available documents, budget

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5. PHASE 4: KICKOFF

5.1 Kickoff Meeting Agenda (60 minutes)

Time	Topic	Owner
0-10 min	Introductions	Both
10-20 min	Project Overview	CEPHO
20-30 min	Methodology Walkthrough	CEPHO
30-40 min	Timeline & Milestones	Both
40-50 min	Communication Plan	Both
50-60 min	Q&A, Next Steps	Both

5.2 Kickoff Deliverables

Project Charter:

Element	Description
Project Name	Official project identifier
Objectives	3-5 specific, measurable goals
Scope	What's included and excluded
Timeline	Key milestones and dates
Team	Roles and responsibilities
Communication	Meeting cadence, channels
Success Criteria	How we measure completion

Communication Plan:

Communication	Frequency	Format	Participants
Status Update	Weekly	Email	All stakeholders
Working Session	As needed	Video call	Working team
Milestone Review	Per milestone	Video call	Decision makers
Final Presentation	End of engagement	In-person/Video	All stakeholders

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6. PHASE 5: ACTIVE ENGAGEMENT

6.1 Engagement Workflow

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│                          ACTIVE ENGAGEMENT WORKFLOW
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├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────
│
│
│  WEEK 1: DEEP DIVE
│
│  ├── Document analysis
│
│  ├── Market research
│
│  ├── Competitive analysis
│
│  └── Initial findings review
│
│
│
│  WEEK 2: SME ANALYSIS
│
│  ├── AI-SME expert team review
│
│  ├── Gap analysis (SME Success DNA)
│
│  ├── Risk assessment
│
│  └── Recommendations development
│
│
│
│  WEEK 3: SYNTHESIS
│
│  ├── Consolidate findings
│
│  ├── Draft deliverables
│
│  ├── Internal review
│
│  └── Client preview
│
```

```
│
│
│  WEEK 4: DELIVERY
│
│  ├── Final deliverables
│
│  ├── Presentation
│
│  ├── Q&A and discussion
│
│  └── Next steps planning
│
│
│
└──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────
```

6.2 Status Reporting

Weekly Status Report Template:

```
# [Project Name] - Weekly Status Report
**Week of:** [Date]
**Prepared by:** [Name]

## Summary
[2-3 sentence overview of progress]

## Completed This Week
- [Activity 1]
- [Activity 2]
- [Activity 3]

## In Progress
- [Activity 1] - [% complete]
- [Activity 2] - [% complete]

## Planned Next Week
- [Activity 1]
- [Activity 2]

## Risks/Issues
| Risk/Issue | Impact | Mitigation | Status |
|------------|--------|------------|--------|
| [Description] | H/M/L | [Action] | Open/Closed |

## Decisions Needed
- [Decision 1] - By [Date]

## Next Meeting
[Date/Time]
```

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7. OPTIMIZATION STRATEGIES

7.1 Time Optimization

Activity	Current Time	Optimized Time	Method
Initial Response	24 hours	4 hours	Templates, alerts
Document Collection	5 days	2 days	Automated requests
Discovery Call	60 min	45 min	Structured agenda
System Setup	4 hours	1 hour	Automation
Deep Dive	5 days	3 days	Parallel processing

7.2 Quality Optimization

Quality Factor	Improvement	Implementation
Consistency	Standardized templates	Template library
Completeness	Checklists	Mandatory fields
Accuracy	Peer review	Review gates
Timeliness	SLAs	Automated reminders

7.3 Automation Opportunities

Process	Automation Type	Tool
Lead capture	Form to CRM	Lightfield
Welcome email	Email sequence	Lightfield
Document requests	Automated reminders	Lightfield
Status updates	Scheduled reports	The Brain
Meeting scheduling	Calendar integration	Calendly

8. METRICS & KPIs

8.1 Onboarding Metrics

Metric	Target	Measurement
Response Time	< 4 hours	Time from inquiry to first response
Qualification Rate	> 60%	% of leads that qualify
Discovery Completion	> 80%	% that complete discovery
Kickoff Rate	> 70%	% that reach kickoff
Time to Kickoff	< 7 days	Days from first contact to kickoff
Client Satisfaction	> 4.5/5	Post-kickoff survey

8.2 Engagement Metrics

Metric	Target	Measurement
On-Time Delivery	> 90%	% of milestones met on time
Scope Adherence	> 85%	% delivered within scope
Client Satisfaction	> 4.5/5	Post-engagement survey
Repeat Engagement	> 40%	% that return for more work
Referral Rate	> 25%	% that refer new clients

9. TEMPLATES & RESOURCES

9.1 Document Templates

Template	Purpose	Location
Discovery Notes	Capture discovery call	/templates/discovery-notes.md
Qualification Scorecard	Score and qualify leads	/templates/qualification.md
Project Charter	Formalize engagement	/templates/project-charter.md
Status Report	Weekly updates	/templates/status-report.md
Kickoff Deck	Present methodology	/templates/kickoff-deck.md

9.2 Email Templates

Template	Trigger	Location
Initial Response	New inquiry	/templates/emails/initial-response.md
Discovery Scheduling	Post-qualification	/templates/emails/discovery-invite.md
Document Request	Post-discovery	/templates/emails/document-request.md
Kickoff Confirmation	Pre-kickoff	/templates/emails/kickoff-confirm.md
Welcome Email	Post-kickoff	/templates/emails/welcome.md

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10. CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

10.1 Feedback Collection

- Post-discovery survey (quick pulse)
- Post-kickoff survey (detailed)
- Post-engagement survey (comprehensive)
- Quarterly client interviews

10.2 Process Review

- Monthly metrics review
- Quarterly process audit
- Annual methodology refresh
- Continuous template updates

Document Control:

- Owner: CEPHO Operations
- Last Updated: January 15, 2026
- Next Review: April 15, 2026